

SHIRLEY

BY JIM BISHOP

World War II began for me when I gave my fraternity pin to a cute Pi Phi from Sherman, Texas. I was in my junior year in the school of Architecture at the University of Oklahoma. It was 1942 and I was a member of Phi Gamma Delta fraternity. We had had a very successful summer rush and as a result had pledged a good freshman class. In spite of the fact that we were in the war by then, everyone was looking forward to a good year. Many of us realized it might be our last before entering the service. We just hoped to be able to finish it, before having to go.

I had been appointed as Social Chairman for our house. This placed the responsibility for all social activities in our fraternity under my direction. Parties, dances, special dinners, picnics, whatever, were planned by myself and my committee. It was up to us to see that all such events were successful, and hopefully the envy of all other fraternities on campus. The first big duty at the beginning of the school year was to set up the schedule for "Blind Dates" with the new pledges from all the sororities on campus. I had to work with the social chairman at each sorority on a schedule which would match up our new pledges with theirs for "Blind Dates". We scheduled dates for each weekend with three different sororities. An example would be Friday night, Kappa Alpha Theta; Saturday night, Pi Beta Phi; Sunday night, Kappa Kappa Gamma. Then on the following weekend, we would schedule with three different sororities. The purpose of this whole scheme, of course, was to get our new pledges acquainted with girls on campus, and vice versa. It also gave our upperclassmen a chance to look over the new crop of sorority pledges. It was an interesting experience, but it was not always simple, nor was it without problems.

I'm called to the telephone.

"Hi, Jim, this is Madge at the Kappa house. We're scheduled for this Saturday, you know. Could we possibly have our girls come for dinner? Our kitchen's closed Saturday night and we've told them what great meals you all have over there." Dinners at the Phi Gam house were the talk of the campus. We were known for having some of the best food you could get in the entire university. Our cook, "Ma Perkins" was one of the best.

"We can probably swing it. How many you got this year?"

Twenty two." This meant that our dining room would be full and overflowing. We would have to set up extra tables in the Trophy Room and also in our house mother's sitting room. But that wasn't unusual for us. We always managed.

I asked Madge, "When do you want to get together and do our match ups? If you don't have a nine o'clock class in the morning, I could meet you at the Union for a coke and we could take care of it then."

"That's super for me," Madge answered. "My first class is at ten. See you tomorrow, Jim."

Making up the dating schedules required the ability to try to match two people together who had never seen one another before, that you hoped would be compatible so that they would both enjoy themselves. Things didn't always work out good, however, but we always did what we could to avoid obvious problems or mismatching. You wouldn't want to pair a six foot athletic type sorority pledge with a five foot three brain child. Some of the sororities would have there lists made up with the real knock outs at the top of the list. The closer you came to the bottom, the more likely you would find the kind that got taken home early. That, however, was a practice that was forbidden at the Phi Gam house. We prided ourselves on HOSPITALITY and on being GENTLEMEN. The night of first "Blind Dates" I called all the pledges together before they left to get their dates and told them.

There's one thing you people have to understand about blind dates. The purpose of this whole thing is to help you get acquainted on campus. You have to get known in the sororities...their pledges have to get known in the fraternities. Now...all the girls that come over here tonight aren't going to be queen of the campus. Some will knock your socks off. Some might just curl your socks. But REGARDLESS of looks, personality, or a complete lack of either, you WILL treat your date with respect. You WILL act like you're enjoying it. You WILL dance with your date. You Will introduce her properly to all members in your presence. You WILL have a good time. You WILL NOT, I repeat, WILL NOT take your date home early! Anyone leaving this house before thirty minutes till curfew will find themselves waxing the Lounge floor all night. Keep this thought in mind, guys. She might not look beautiful, but her Daddy might have a string of oil wells. Now get out of here, and go get'em!"

It was during "Blind Dates" of that year that I met my Pi Phi.

Her name was Shirley.

She came to our house for Sunday night dinner and happened to sit on my right with her blind date next to her. I sat at the head of our table. We had eaten a marvelous meal. Ma Perkins had outdone herself for the Pi Beta Phis, because they were our sister sorority. We always tried to do things extra special for them. Our singing during the meal, and while we were waiting fo desert had impressed all of the girls. Some looked as if they might swoon any minute. When we finished singing "My Pi Phi Girl" in full harmony, they were all mesmerized and misty eyed.

Desert was served. It was chocolate pie with a thick, fluffy, beautifully browned meringue on top. Now, whenever any kind of meringue pie or other gooshy kind of desert was served and you had new, unsuspecting, naive freshmen pledges at the table, it was time for one of our fun games. It was called "Coverup".

"Okeh, everyone," the head of the table would say, "We're going to play Coverup. It goes like this. Everyone places their hands down on either side of your plate. When I say the magic word 'Coverup', everyone puts their hands over their desert as fast as they can. The last one to coverup his desert forfeits it to me."

All of this preparatory talk was subterfuge. After the word Coverup was spoken, there would be a quick moving of hands, everyone eager to cover their pie so they wouldn't lose it. As soon as that happened, someone sitting next to the unsuspecting pledge would reach over and push their hands down into the pie. This surprising occurrence always resulted in howls of laughter from everyone, and dirty looks from our housemother. In her opinion, it was a most undignified proceeding, one in which young gentlemen shouldn't indulge.

We played Coverup that night at my table, and I pushed little Miss Shirley's hands down in the middle of her chocolate pie. She was embarrassed, but she was a good sport about it she laughed with us, and that girl blushed...my, how she blushed. She would have covered her face with her hands, but they were covered with chocolate meringue pie. So she blushed. And she was beautiful. And I was smitten by her ash blonde hair, beautiful white teeth, and a chest any girl could be proud of. The table waiters brought warm damp towels to all the victims of our game and helped to clean up the mess. We also gave them a fresh piece of pie. We got Shirley and her date cleaned up, as he had fallen for it too. Then we all joined in enjoying our desert, and our meal was finished in high good humor. Shirley looked at me several times and by the time our dinner came to its end with the final song, she had wrapped one ole Oklohoma boy around her little finger.

The rest of the evening was spent in our basement Lounge dancing. The Lounge was a big room which ran the full depth of the house. It had a beautiful, shiny terrazzo floor which was perfect for dancing. I tried to meet all the other Pi Phi pledges that night, but it was hard for me to concentrate. I kept watching Shirley, and she kept watching me. I danced with her twice and began to learn something about her background. When time came for the dates to be taken back to the Pi Phi house, I was wishing I were the one who would be walking Shirley home. It took me a long time to get a telephone line into the Pi Phi house that night, but I finally got one. We talked for almost an hour and that conversation opened a new chapter in my life.

The next few weeks were difficult for me. I wanted to see, and be with Shirley whenever I could. She had to go through "Blind Dates". It was a sorority rule. So we met for coke dates when we didn't have classes, or sat on the campus between classes. We went to church together, any way we could manage to be together, we did it. We took long walks in the rain. The Pi Phi social chairman finally took pity on us and let Shirley skip a few of her blind dates so we could attend some of our fraternity functions together. Not long after the ordeal of "Blind Dates" was over, we were pinned. She was a very sentimental girl, so she cried when I gave her my Phi Gam pin.

Although the war was getting more serious, we tried not to notice. I was classified 1-A in the draft with my local draft board back home and I figured I was going to have to do something, if I expected to be able to finish my junior year. The Navy had the V-5 and V-12 programs. Under those programs, you could enlist in the Navy and they would let you remain in school, get your degree, and then send you to flight school to train as a pilot, or they would make you a line officer. I didn't like the idea of trying to land airplanes on the deck of an aircraft carrier, especially at night. But, I could definitely see myself as a Navy officer directing the construction of airfields, or docks, or submarine bases. I liked the looks of the Navy officer's whites, and besides that, it just seemed like a lot cleaner way to fight a war.

I should have known better.

Shirley was an Army Brat.

She had been born on an Army post, and had lived in half a dozen states by the time she entered college. Her father was a full colonel, regular army, on the staff of the Eighth Service Command. She loved the Army and all that went with it. She loved her Daddy and all the things he represented. And if I was going to do the right thing, it sure didn't include becoming a Naval Officer.

I had been through two years of Artillery R.O.T.C. training in my first two years at O.U. I hadn't been excited enough about it to go on into Advanced R.O.T.C. in my junior year. That would have lead to a reserve commission in the Field Artillery. The Army had a program that was similiar to the Navy's. It was designated as the A.S.T.P. The initials stood for Army Specialized Training Program. Under that plan, after enlisting, you were allowed to complete the school year, you were then called to active duty and sent to take Infantry Basic Training. After Basic, you were sent back to college to complete your degree and then you would be given a commission as a second lieutenant in the Army Corps of Engineers. It was ARMY, so Shirley was all for it. Shirley was for it, so I was for it. So....I'll build bridges and Army bases.

I checked with my draft board back home and they told me my chances of finishing the school year were slim, to poor. I was told I would probably get called before the end of school. The following week I went to the R.O.T.C. building and signed up for the A.S.T.P.. I took my physical, swore to defend the United States against all enemies, both foreign and domestic, and was officially sworn in as a member of the United States Army Reserve. Serial number 18107217 was given to me on a set of dog tags. Look out Hitler!

The rest of that school year was made up of studying, parties, frat dances, long nights and weekends in the Architectural School labs, and long, lovely walks in the rain with Shirley. Her parents came to visit her one weekend in November and we took them for dinner to the Copper Kettle restaurant where we had carved our initials into one of the tables. The Colonel seemed like a nice person. I did my best to impress him with my military knowledge and bearing. I wanted him to be able to say, "This young man will make a fine officer, and a good husband for my daughter." Her mother seemed concerned that Shirley had gotten so involved with someone like me that early in her college career. I wasn't too high on her list, I'm afraid.

We went home one weekend to Ponca City so she could meet my parents. They thought she was grand and they hit it off together. I proudly showed her around to everyone I could find who was still in town. I was firmly convinced that this was the girl I was going to marry. At that time, I think She believed it, too.

Back at the university, I was struggling to keep my grades up. I had very foolishly enrolled in twenty two hours of classes at the beginning of the year, and it was beginning to take its toll on my scholastic abilities. Differential Calculus was giving me a hard time, I was carrying a strong D yet I was pulling A's in all of my architecture courses. My advisor, Professor Kamphoefner advised me to drop Calculus before I failed it. "Take a W in the course," he said, "and concentrate on your architecture courses." That good advice would allow me to finish up my year with good grades. I got more restless, the nearer it came to the end of the second semester. The urge to get it all over with and go on into the Army was consuming me. The end of the year finally came and I said goodbye to Shirley and went home to bid farewell to my parents.

The bus that took me to Fort Sill, Oklahoma left my town on a Sunday morning. My Mom didn't want to go to the bus to say goodbye. We did our ritual hug and kisses at the house, then she turned and walked back inside, wiping her eyes on the hem of her apron as I'd seen her do so many times over the years we had spent together. Dad drove me to the station, in the 1940 Oldsmobile Torpedo Body which I had thought was

the grandest car in the world. That was the car that I had kept washed and polished with white sidewall tires gleaming, in exchange for taking it for some of my dates. I rubbed my hands across the shiny seat covers, wondering how long it might be before I was able to ride in, or drive that car again. Dad was all serious and trying not to show any emotion as I bought my ticket and got onto the bus. He grabbed my hand and pulled me back to him and squeezed our bodies together. I felt that familiar stubble of beard on his face as his cheek rubbed mine.

"Take care of your self, Son." were his parting words. Then he turned and left.

The bus was full. All the seats were taken, some had two people crowded into them. There were servicemen, civilians, children, it was a very uncomfortable ride that I experienced that day. I spent most of the time standing in the step at the front door of the bus. Once in awhile I was able to sit on the edge of the step and rest my feet. That was the first of many rides I was to have on crowded buses during my three years in the Army.

When we arrived at the Reception Center in Fort Sill, it was late in the day and I was tired, depressed and anxiously waiting to see what was going to happen next. World War II had officially begun for Private Jim Bishop, ASN 18107217.